

The Freedom Tower. Twenty-six stories of archive servers humming behind an ornate facade. The most beautiful foreclosure filing cabinet in the Western Hemisphere.



You look like a car wreck, Cutter.



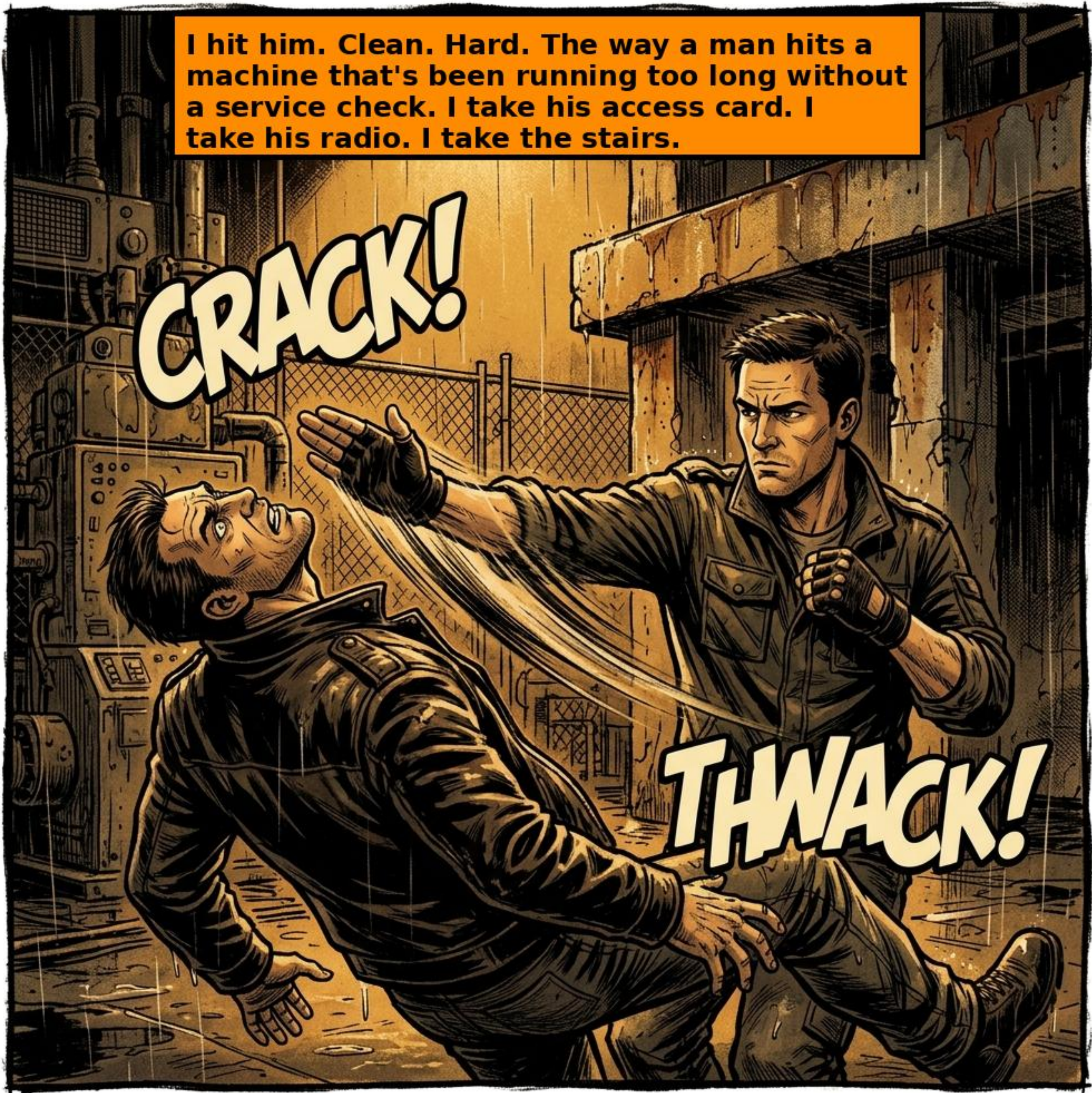


**Clean slate. He says it like it's a gift.
Like the Drowned District doesn't exist.**

I hit him. Clean. Hard. The way a man hits a machine that's been running too long without a service check. I take his access card. I take his radio. I take the stairs.

CRACK!

THWACK!





Level 14. The Grid Terminal. A room-sized mainframe of magnetic drum readers. The hum is physical. I feel it in my back teeth.



Axel. Kallan confirmed your mother's file is extracted and decrypted. She is not in the server anymore.

She's out. The file used as a leash around my neck for eleven years. Sitting in my jacket pocket on a spool the size of my fist.



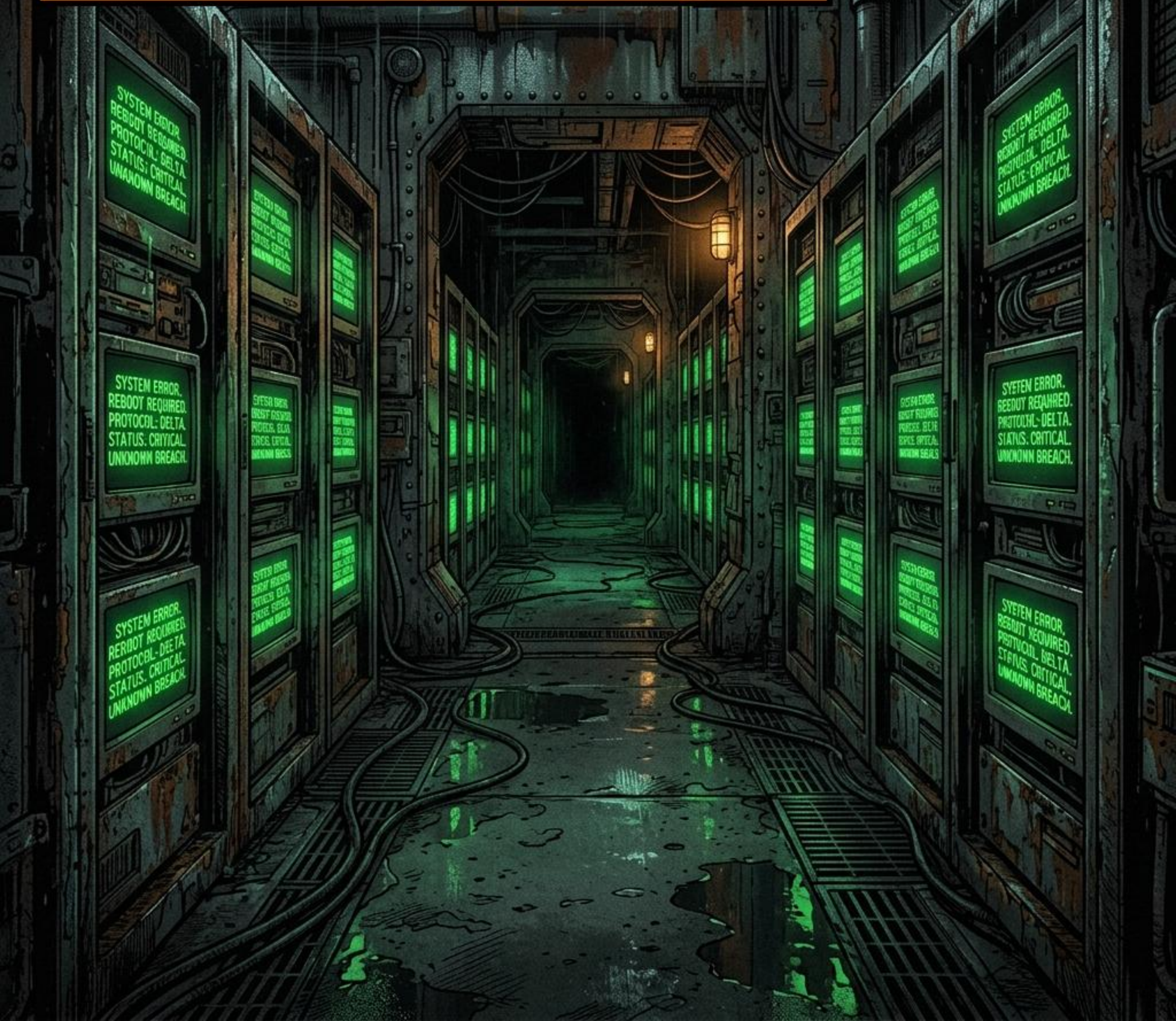
**A selective reformat. Debt records.
Repossession orders. Foreclosure files only.
The infrastructure logic stays intact. The
pumps keep running. The sector doesn't flood.**





I thread the Tape into the master drive. The terminal accepts it with the sound of a lock recognizing the right key for the first time.

ARCHIVE REFORMAT IN PROGRESS. ESTIMATED COMPLETION: 14 MINUTES. Every debt chain in the Drowned District. Quietly unwinding.





HALT THE PROCESS, CUTTER. RIGHT NOW.

All two hundred and ten pounds of me. Every mile of the last fifty-one days. Every foreclosure notice. Holding a door shut for six more minutes. Come back in fourteen minutes, Vance. I'll have a receipt ready.



I think about my mother's voice on those drones—synthesized, weaponized. The real version is in my jacket pocket, small enough to hold in one hand.

DRIVE PROGRESS: 87%



DRIP
DRIP



SPLASH-



CLICK-CLACK



REFORMAT COMPLETE. The Drowned District's debt is cleared. The infrastructure is intact. Nobody drowned tonight. File whatever audit you want. The Grid already answered it.